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Konko AI: Automating Work with AI Agents

Sales is the one function shared by every business on the planet. There is massive opportunity in using AI to automate the many repetitive sales tasks so human beings can focus on uniquely human tasks like building trust and closing deals. I also love that this approach gives teams more time to enjoy life beyond work.¹

— Jean Marc Goguikian, CEO and Co-founder

Our AI agent has already exceeded human performance, and we see tremendous opportunity to increase its ability to understand leads (their priorities, their concerns, what drives them to 'yes'), handle objections, persuade, delight and close our customer's leads.

— Michael Haddad, CTO and Co-Founder

Introduction

As Jean Marc Goguikian, CEO of Konko AI, was leaving the gym, a notification from Michael Haddad, Konko's CTO came up on his phone, "Just wrapped our seventh demo with a medical clinic in Costa Rica. Same story: overwhelmed front office, missed appointments, patients waiting days for basic information." The company had been focused on fintech companies that offered loan origination products. While fintech implementations took months to customize, they had secured two signed deals and four verbal commitments from clinics in less than a month. With over 100,000 healthcare providers in Latin America facing similar patient engagement challenges, this market promised something that had eluded them in fintech: standardization. As Goguikian packed up his gym bag, he knew they needed to decide quickly: Should they double down on financial services or shift focus to medical clinics?

The startup had built a proprietary AI agent system that empowered inbound sales teams to close more deals by automatically surfacing and engaging qualified leads who were ready to buy. The agent also excelled at re-targeting leads who had shown purchase intent but dropped out of the funnel. Unlike other agent systems that merely connected LLMs or tools without coherent reasoning, Konko's

¹ Unless otherwise noted, quotes from the co-founders are from interviews conducted in 2024 and 2025.

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architecture was designed to emulate human cognition by coordinating perception, memory, and decision-making through a central orchestrator—mirroring how top salespeople assessed intent, adapted approaches, and guided conversations to closing deals.

A year earlier, Konko had launched a different product—a developer platform for private LLM deployment. However, as the infrastructure market became increasingly crowded—with well-funded competitors (including hyperscalers like AWS, Azure and VC-backed start-ups like Together AI) racing to commoditize core capabilities—the team reassessed their strategic positioning. Through ongoing customer discovery, they identified a sharper, more urgent pain point: businesses wanted applied AI solutions that could drive tangible business outcomes, not just infrastructure. Konko made their first pivot from an infrastructure platform to create AI sales agents for fintech loan originators (where originators assisted borrowers in securing loans).

By May 2024, Konko had secured three customers, each making Konko’s AI agent a top strategic priority. However, scaling within financial services was proving challenging as each loan originator had radically different sales workflows requiring extensive customization. What started as one product had evolved into three distinct versions of their agent. The focused vertical they had envisioned was revealing itself as dozens of micro-markets. Their customers wanted the AI agents to replicate their current systems or certain tasks within the sales pipeline. In some instances, this meant mostly collecting information for their back-end loan origination algorithms. In other cases, the agent’s role was to gather information to make the human salesperson’s job more efficient. In the third case, the agent was expected to qualify the lead by gathering and evaluating information provided by the prospective customer and then pass on the lead to the salesperson.

As of January 2025, Konko’s AI sales agent² had delivered 40% revenue growth across the first three fintech clients. The process had been intensive: identifying the customer segment, evaluating its potential, finding design partners and initial customers, building prototypes, and convincing salespeople to share their processes so Konko could train its agents. Over the course of eight months working with fintechs, Konko had laid a powerful foundation: a flexible agent architecture proven in high-friction and regulated environments and a repeatable process for training high performing agents on real-world sales behavior. The question now was which market to apply those assets in. The company was too small to serve two distinct segments.

Founding Story

Background

After graduating from Duke University, Goguikian specialized in financial services consulting at Booz & Company. He joined Harvard Business School in 2016, where he delved into the tech and startup landscape. After graduation, Goguikian worked at the Boston Consulting Group in financial services and software consulting. He later joined Fairmatic, a seed-stage AI-powered insurance startup, as the CEO’s Chief of Staff. Goguikian played a key role in scaling the company to over \$10 million in annual recurring revenue. “I touched every part of the business and never felt lost or overwhelmed. It gave me the confidence I needed to say: I’m ready to be a founder.”

Haddad studied electrical and computer engineering at the University of Florida before pursuing an MS/PhD track at UCLA focused on nanoscale semiconductor materials. Seeking a faster pace of

² AI agents were software programs that leveraged multiple large language models (LLMs) models for specific tasks. Unlike traditional workflows, AI agents were able to carry out tasks and complete actions on a user’s behalf.

innovation, he left academia to join Intel, where he became known for automating complex engineering workflows. After Harvard Business School, Haddad co-founded Carriage, an electric vehicle charging platform, before joining Scoot Networks (later acquired by Bird). He subsequently worked at C3 AI, where he “learned how to lead technical teams toward a big, complex vision.” Haddad moved to Retain AI, honing his skills in building data-driven products in a fast-paced startup environment. Goguikian and Haddad met at Harvard Business School and reconnected during the COVID pandemic while living in Brooklyn, New York.

Early Days

In early 2023, Haddad had been following advances in Large Language Models (LLMs) closely. He showed Goguikian demos of GPT-3 and Midjourney that sparked their excitement about generative AI’s potential. More than just making knowledge and creative workers faster and more efficient, generative AI had the power to elevate their work, pushing the boundaries of what was possible. Moreover, models were becoming more powerful at an unprecedented rate, suggesting that a flood of application development was imminent. “We could see that within a few years, every workflow would need to be reimaged with AI at its core,” Haddad explained. “The question wasn’t if, but when.”

Before launching their company, the two spent weeks establishing explicit personal and professional objectives and creating detailed “personal user manuals” outlining their working styles. (See **Exhibit 1: Founding Principles**). This cultural foundation would shape their decision-making, feedback processes, and alignment under pressure. It would also help them avoid co-founder drift during pivots—a common failure point for many startup teams. Goguikian reflected, “Everything seemed to line up perfectly. We had the right mix of skills and experience to tackle this market and had great communication and chemistry. It felt fated.” Goguikian and Haddad left their respective startups to launch Konko AI and by June, they were working full-time on the company.

While both were convinced of generative AI’s transformative potential, they recognized the significant hurdles for developers: privacy concerns with gated API models and prohibitive usage-based pricing for scaling applications. They conducted interviews with over 100 AI builders, saw repeatable needs, and created infrastructure tools to meet those needs. By early 2024, Konko had secured an oversubscribed \$1M pre-seed round. Companies expressed interest but lacked technical expertise to build useful AI applications. The process of commercializing the tools revealed a landscape that was full of developer experimentation but short on commitment. Many prospective customers were exploring generative AI in theory, but lacked the internal talent—or urgency—to implement real systems, making sales cycles unpredictable and shallow.

FinTech Opportunity

Konko’s entry into the fintech market began when they received a call from Javier Mancilla, an executive at a fintech loan origination company, who was drawn to their focus on security. Mancilla explained that he needed more than secure infrastructure: “I need help actually building the thing on top of it. I don’t really know how to manipulate this technology,” Goguikian recalled. This conversation charted a new direction as the founders learned that most companies in 2024 did not know how to build AI-based solutions to critical business problems. The team began working with Mancilla to identify specific pain points in financial services, discovering that document verification and slow loan application processing were key issues. Goguikian noted, “The time-to-yes is very important in these financial services transactions. The quicker you can go from ‘loan application submitted’ to ‘loan approved,’ the more likely you are to get the borrower to sign.”

The team undertook a structured discovery process, interviewing over 30 fintech executives and uncovering a consistent pattern: while many were excited about AI's potential, they lacked the in-house expertise to implement it effectively—and were particularly eager to use it to accelerate growth through automated customer outreach and engagement. Moreover, the infrastructure they had already built provided a strong technical foundation for deploying scalable and secure AI agents—positioning them to move quickly and credibly into this emerging application layer. The question was: would an AI agent actually deliver on the business case?

The opportunity in loan origination was substantial, representing a \$30 billion market with 100,000 loan originators in the U.S. underwriting trillions in loans annually. (See **Exhibit 2: Market for AI Inbound Sales Agent**). Konko's research indicated that inefficiencies led to over \$2 trillion worth of loans being abandoned before completion, with 48% of consumers encountering issues when trying to open accounts online. Konko's AI agent promised to automate the loan application pipeline using a conversational approach, available 24/7 with access to all necessary knowledge and systems. The agent could adjust to each customer's preferred style—taking either a slower conversational approach to learn about customer needs or a more efficient transactional path.

The financial services space, despite its massive size and clear pain points, remained largely unaddressed. "Everyone was trying to build general AI assistants," Goguikian noted. "But financial services has unique requirements—security, compliance, integration with existing systems. You can't just deploy a general-purpose chatbot and expect it to understand loan origination." Specialized agents could be trained in industry-specific data and integrated with existing financial systems. They could handle routine tasks like document processing and customer inquiries while maintaining compliance with regulatory requirements. Konko's early customer contracts proved this point: financial institutions were willing to pay premium prices for solutions that understood their specific needs. They recognized sales agents presented a massive opportunity regardless of the fintech's success. However, they needed a specific, urgent use case as a wedge to open the market.

By May 2024, Konko had secured their first three fintech customers, validating their pivot from a horizontal infrastructure platform to AI sales agents for loan originators. All three initial customers had come through investors. The team worked closely with these early customers to build business cases that were "ambitious enough to be compelling, but also realistic enough to be believable." Konko created a system of AI agents that assisted customers through the loan pipeline using a conversational approach, helping them when they got stuck and suggesting alternate products if they didn't qualify. Implementation however revealed distinct challenges. "We learned that the devil is in the details when it comes to building AI agents," Goguikian explained. Implementation across the three customers highlighted the diversity of needs—even within the seemingly homogenous customer persona of 'fintech loan originators.'

AI Agents

Agent Design

Konko's approach to building AI agents evolved through several iterations. Initially, they modeled the agent after an online form, but this proved ineffective. "The way that a user interacts with a questionnaire is very different from the way a user interacts with another human, and a big advantage of using an AI agent is to humanize customer interactions," Goguikian explained. Agents were available 24x7, and they never got tired or sick. They could converse in multiple languages and most importantly, documented every interaction, generating data to continuously improve the system. Agents could also be reconfigured to experiment with new approaches for presenting information and

following up with disengaged customers. Each approach could be tested, and the most effective ones incorporated into future agent iterations.

After starting with the automation of the online form, the team decided to step back and observe why certain sales representatives significantly outperformed others. For example, Ana, one of the top performers, had developed a sophisticated system for categorizing and engaging leads that delivered conversion rates 30-50% higher than her peers. She categorized leads into “prepared and motivated leads” who came ready with specific requirements, and “curious leads looking to learn” who needed more education. For prepared leads, Ana would lead with open-ended questions about context rather than immediately jumping into form fields. Goguikian explained, “If someone says ‘Hi, I want to start a company in Portugal,’ our first version of the agent would say, ‘Oh, great! What’s your nationality?’” Ana, in contrast, would say, ‘Oh, that’s great! Can you give me a little bit more context on what you’re trying to build?’” This prompted leads to share rich and useful context, which could guide the agent in its interaction. Konko’s changed their approach from simply digitizing forms to emulating this more sophisticated, context-sensitive engagement. A truly effective AI agent needed to mirror the more nuanced, adaptive approach of their best human salespeople – knowing when to follow the process and when to deviate from it for better results.

They soon realized other top performing agents achieved comparable results with vastly different approaches. In some cases, the human salesperson established a deep personal connection, asking questions about the customer’s life and sharing information about themselves. Others focused on obtaining the information as soon as possible, to qualify leads and reach decisions. They did not worry about more complicated cases that required extensive handholding for loan approval. This raised critical questions: Which successful approach should Konko’s agents emulate? Should AI agents develop their own approach distinct from that of human salespeople? Did Konko need different agents to match each sales rep’s strategy? Could these various approaches be combined and deployed based on customer profiles rather than the salesperson’s personal approach?

The team also built a layered system that grew smarter with each customer interaction. The base layer contained common sales intelligence that worked across all customers, and a customization layer that adapted to each financial institution’s specific needs. As they built for more customers and gained deeper understanding of distinct aspects of sales – from identifying intent signals to distinguishing serious customers from casual inquiries – the generic part grew more robust while the custom layer became thinner. This meant programming the AI to gauge customer intent through various signals: how they responded to questions, how much information they volunteered, and how proactive they were in asking their own questions. Only when this “intent gauge” was full would the AI make its pitch – a stark contrast to what Goguikian called “a dumb robot” that tried to push for a sale with every message.

Agent Architecture

Agents utilized LLMs to make decisions and control the flow of applications. The fundamental architecture of AI agents consisted of several key components working together. At their core, agents had a central orchestrator that coordinated activities, a memory module that stored and retrieved information for maintaining context and continuity across interactions, and access to various external tools and APIs to perform specific tasks. This architecture allowed agents to break down complex tasks into manageable steps, develop strategies, and execute actions independently. The architecture featured a feedback loop that enabled continued learning, with clear pathways for both processing inputs and delivering results. (See **Exhibit 3a: AI Agents – Description and Components** and **Exhibit 3b: Evolution of AI Agents**).

Konko developed technical architecture that was more complex than simply connecting to a language model API. The company built a sophisticated system of over 20 specialized sub-agents working in concert, each handling specific cognitive functions or tasks. “It’s not one agent; it’s actually multiple agents. And each of them handles a specific kind of function within the cognition of the bigger system,” Goguikian explained. For example, one sub-agent specialized in lead intent recognition. It continuously analyzed conversation patterns, response latency, and message content to infer how serious a lead was – and dynamically adjusted the tone, pacing, and follow-up strategy based on that signal. This allowed the system to emulate the judgment of a skilled salesperson, prioritizing high-intent leads while gracefully deflecting low-quality ones without wasting time.

An orchestrator agent managed both long-term objectives and immediate interactions, maintaining the overarching goal of closing a sale while addressing immediate customer queries. The system included specialized sub-agents for different scenarios: question-answering, lead qualification, customer intent assessment, and timing of re-engagement. The AI agent integrated with customer relationship management systems (CRMs), scheduling tools, and messaging platforms, appearing in the customer engagement suite as “Kora” or “Ingrid” handling the lead. (See **Exhibit 4: Meet Kora**, the inbound sales rep for loan originators). This sophisticated architecture, combined with insights from top-performing sales representatives, enabled Konko to build agents that could adapt to customer personalities and needs, creating a natural conversation flow that led to higher conversion rates. “We’re trying to emulate how a salesperson would think.” (See **Exhibit 5: How Konko’s AI Agent worked**).

The initial results were encouraging. (See **Exhibit 6a and 6b: Early Data**). Early data indicated that leads handled by their AI agent were 140% more likely to convert than those handled by human sales agents. This success led to increased adoption – customers tripled the volume of leads they assigned to Konko’s AI agent within a month. However, these successes also revealed new challenges. Each implementation required extensive customization of workflows, compliance requirements, and backend integrations, with integration times of 30-40 days consuming dozens of engineering hours. What started as a “custom layer” on top of their base agent became more complex with each client – rather than more standardized. While the potential revenue was significant, the team worried about their ability to scale effectively.

A New Opportunity

After recognizing the scaling challenges in fintech, Konko began systematically exploring new market opportunities. At the end of 2024, Goguikian was describing their system to an old friend who pointed out that medical clinics in many countries faced similar problems handling front-office operations. Initial exploration of clinics in Latin America revealed a different market dynamic. Unlike the heterogeneous world of loan origination, these clinics shared similar pain points: overwhelmed front offices, missed appointments, and patients waiting days for basic information. The problem couldn’t be solved with just a patient portal since patients often wanted to ask follow-up questions, change plans, or escalate issues to medical staff. Initial research suggested thousands of clinics struggled with similar challenges around patient communication and scheduling.

To validate the opportunity, the team spoke to dozens of clinic owners and hosted an online seminar that attracted over 400 sign-ups, including medical association presidents and clinic owners across Mexico, Colombia, and Costa Rica. Konko’s technical assessment indicated they could adapt their existing technology stack with relatively modest engineering effort. Goguikian described, “With 30 days of engineering resources, we could create a version of our product. We could take all the learnings from these three different clients and create a pretty generic and customizable agent that can be

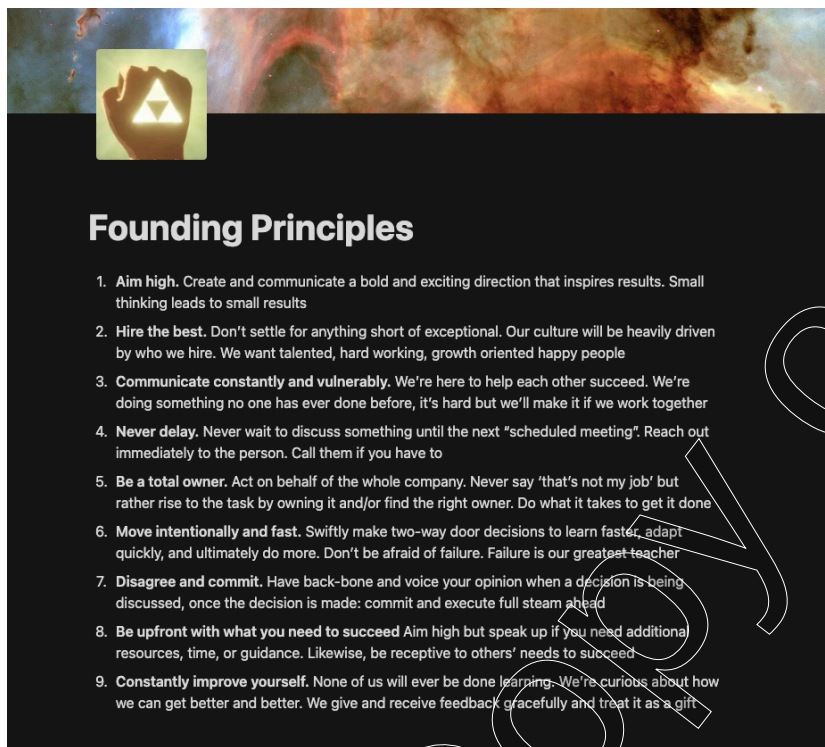
configured to different types of use cases in these markets. This offered the potential to realize our vision of a thin custom layer for each customer.”

As in their first pivot, the ability to leverage their existing technology while targeting a new market made the opportunity particularly attractive. By early 2025, Konko had secured commitments from eight clinics who prepaid for access to their waiting list, while the loan origination market had generated only two new leads with long sales cycles. After early traction with clinics, the team gave themselves seven days to evaluate both verticals and decide—based on recent learnings implementation time, repeatability, and revenue velocity. (See **Exhibit 7**: Comparison between two opportunities).

As Goguikian and Haddad prepared for their next leadership meeting, they faced a critical decision: Should they double down on financial services where they had proven success but faced scaling challenges? Or should they pivot to medical clinics—a potentially larger, more homogeneous market, but one they were just beginning to understand? The decision wasn’t just about market size—it would mean saying no to new fintech clients and potentially disappointing existing ones who wanted custom features. “We need to decide fast,” Goguikian said to Haddad. “Either we’re a fintech company that builds custom AI agents, or we’re building a scalable product for a specific vertical. We can’t be both.”

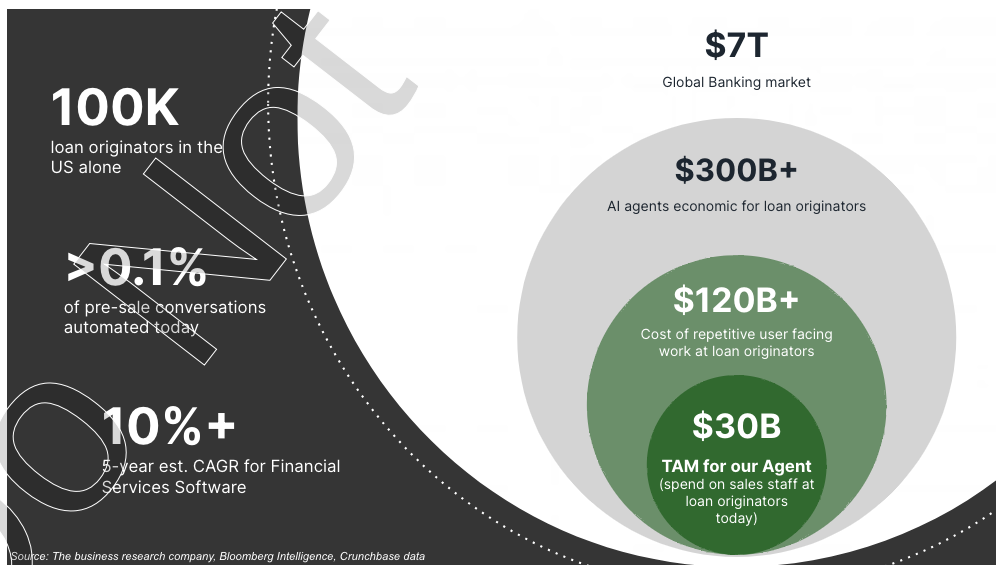
Goguikian and Haddad realized that they had assumed that the loan origination market was also homogenous at the beginning. It was only after several months of working with clients that the heterogeneity in client needs became obvious. Now they faced a critical question: Could they rapidly conduct a customer discovery process that generated enough data to commit to a new and different market?

Exhibit 1 Founding Principles



Source: Company documents.

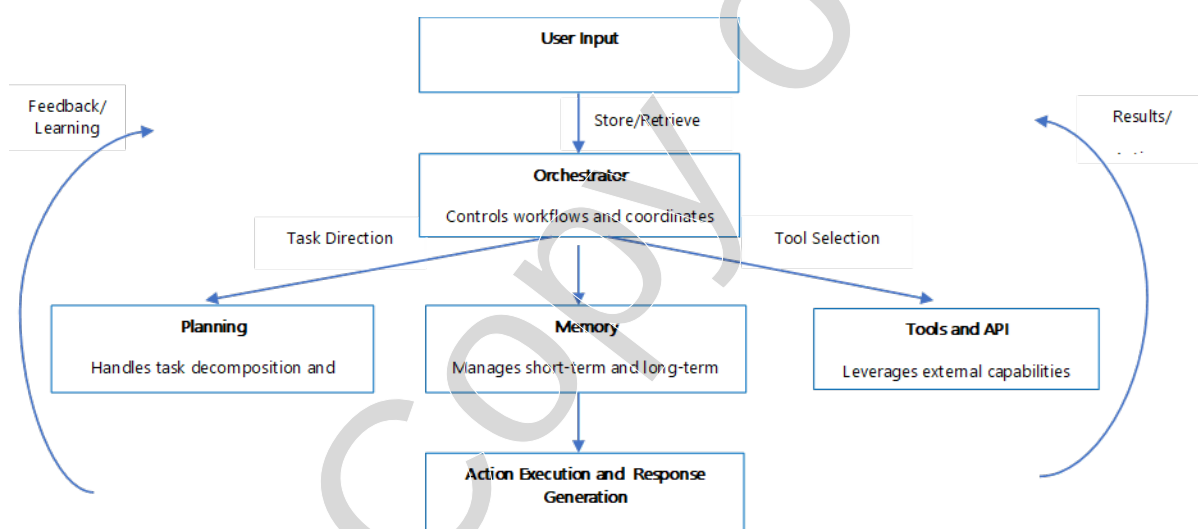
Exhibit 2 Market Size for AI Inbound Sales Agent



Source: Company documents.

Exhibit 3a AI Agents - Description and Components

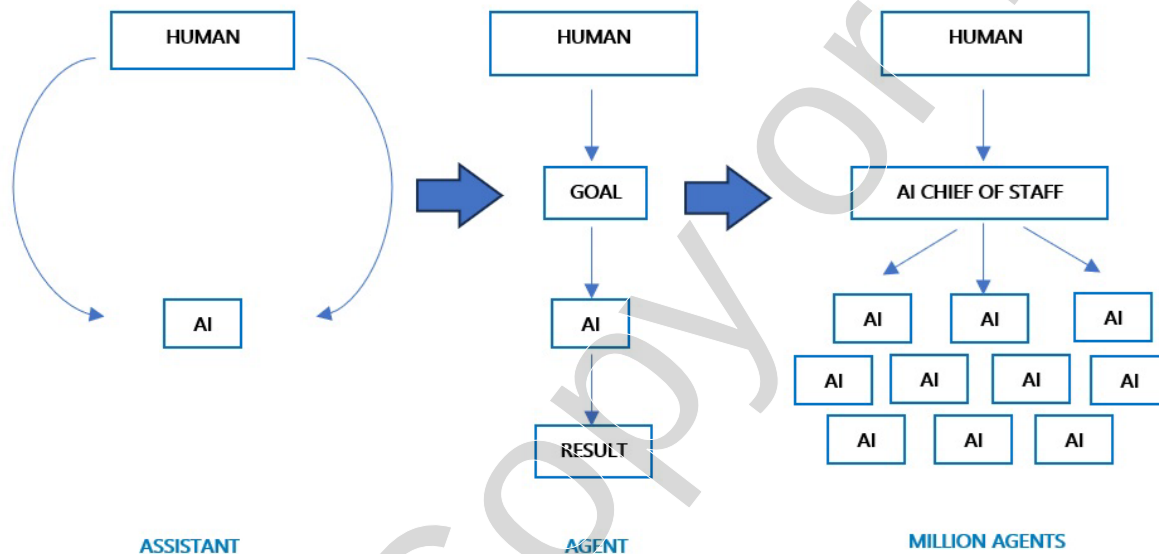
AI agents were software programs that leveraged multiple LLM models for specific tasks and actions. Unlike traditional workflows, AI agents were able to carry out tasks and complete actions on a user's behalf. When a user prompted an LLM, say for travel suggestions for vacation, an LLM returned text that answered the users questions. An AI agent, however, could take that request and actively book flights, reserve hotels, and create an itinerary by interfacing with various travel websites and services. The AI agent market had bifurcated into two distinct segments. On the one hand, large technology companies were releasing general-purpose chatbots that could handle basic customer service tasks. Companies like Salesforce, Anthropic, and OpenAI had announced their own tool-based agents designed to automate routine business processes. On the other end, vertical-specific solutions were emerging for industries like healthcare and retail.



Source: Compiled by casewriters; Anthropic, "Building effective agents," December 19, 2024, <https://www.anthropic.com/research/building-effective-agents>, accessed January 2025; Architecture Bytes – AI, "AI Agents Architecture," May 14, 2024, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FEU6-Il8jjw>, accessed March 2025; FalkorDB, "AI Agents: Memory Systems and Graph Database Integration," November 6, 2024, <https://www.falkordb.com/blog/ai-agents-memory-systems/>, accessed March 2025.

Exhibit 3b Evolution of AI Agents

AI agents would likely evolve for simple assistants to a constellation of agents capable of managing different tasks. The exhibit indicates three stages: basic human-AI interaction (Assistant), goal-directed AI systems (Agent), and complex orchestrated systems where an AI Chief of Staff would coordinate multiple specialized AI agents.



Source: Casewriters; Exponential View, "From ChatGPT to a billion agents," December 4, 2024, <https://www.exponentialview.co/p/from-chatgpt-to-a-billion-agents>, accessed January 2025.

Exhibit 4 Meet Kora, the inbound sales rep for loan originators

Kora is a digital replica of a top sales rep

konko.ai

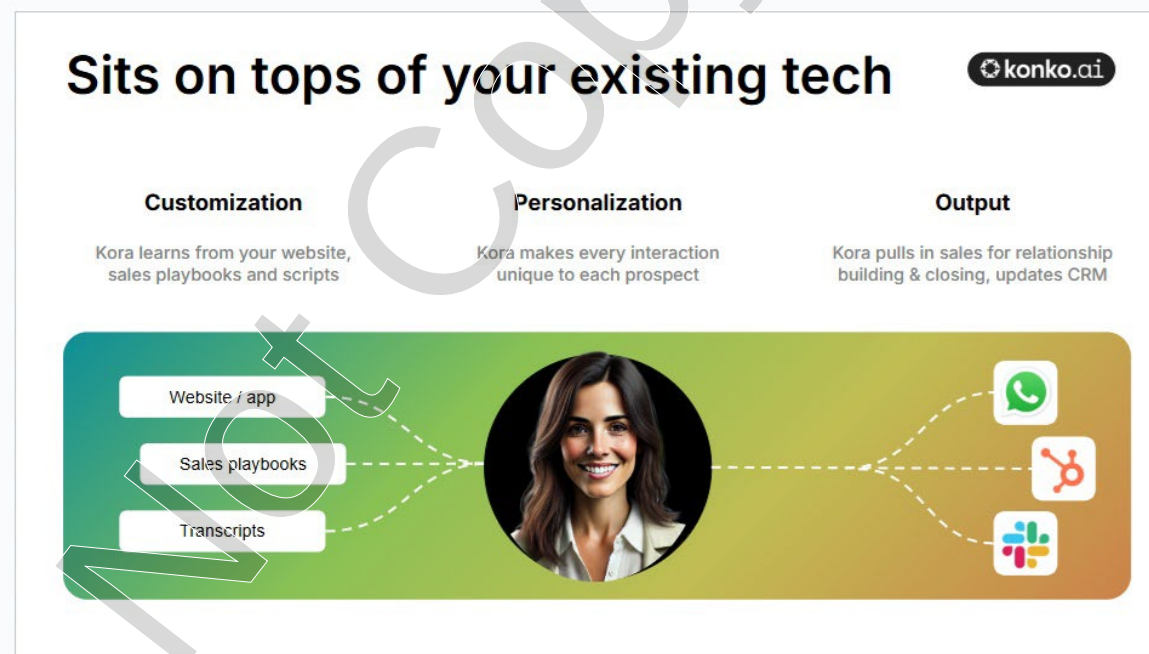
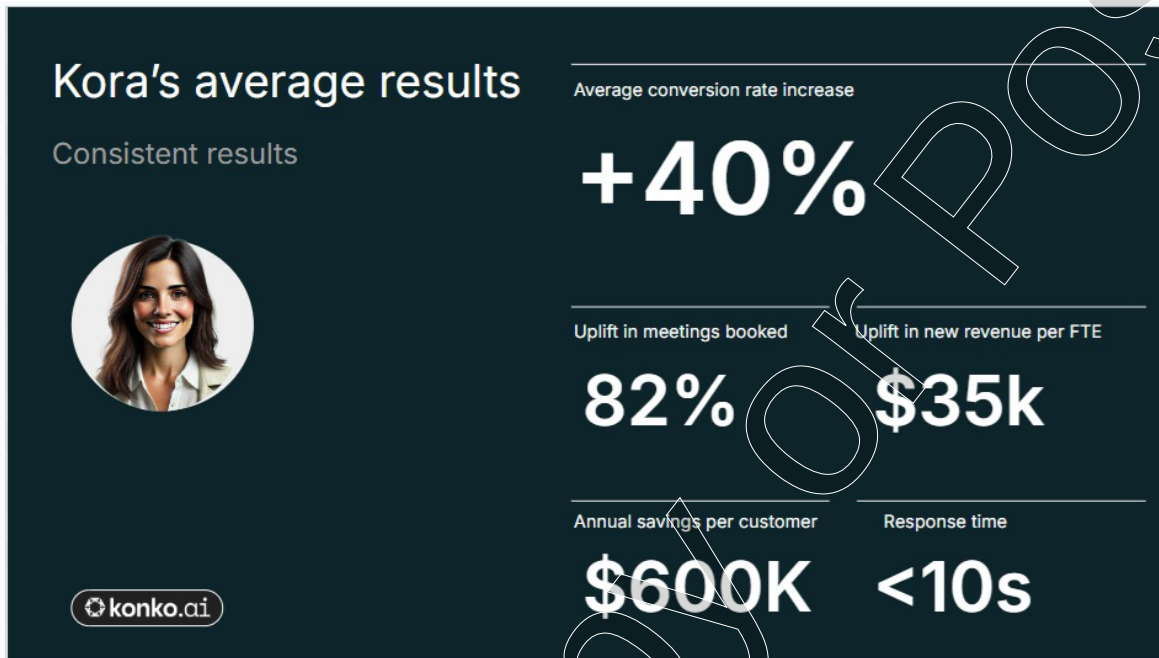
Imagine an AI teammate that:

- 1 Personalizes conversation to every lead
- 2 Never keeps a lead waiting
- 3 Never misses a lead
- 4 Frees your team to do what AI can't

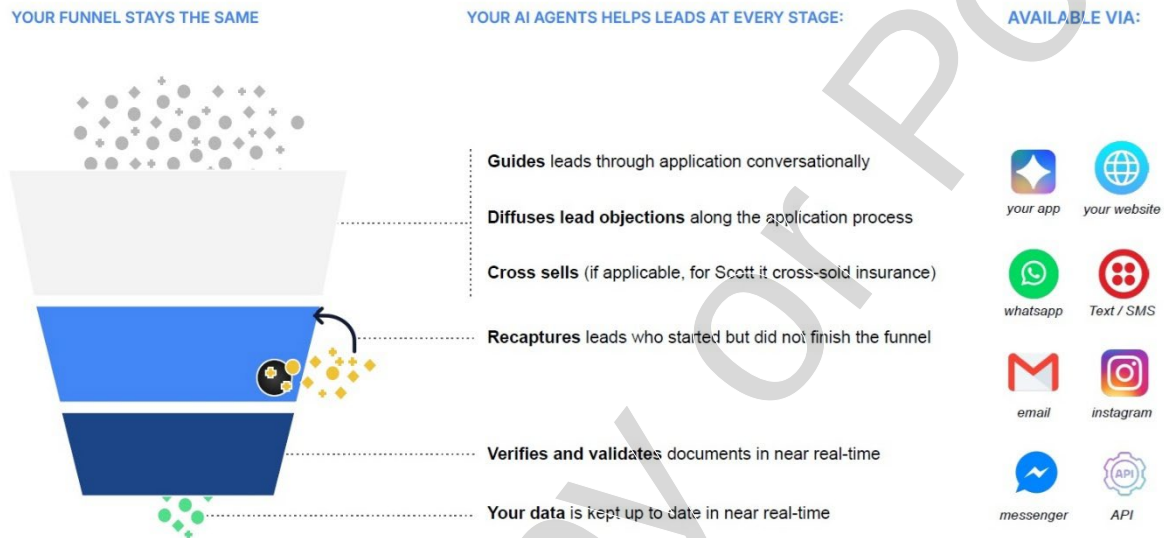


Kora re-targets your inbound leads at scale on autopilot

With Kora	Before Kora
✓ Engages leads	×
✓ Qualifies leads	×
✓ Handles objections	×
✓ Schedules calls	×
✓ Routes leads to sales	×
✓ Updates CRM	×



Source: Company documents.

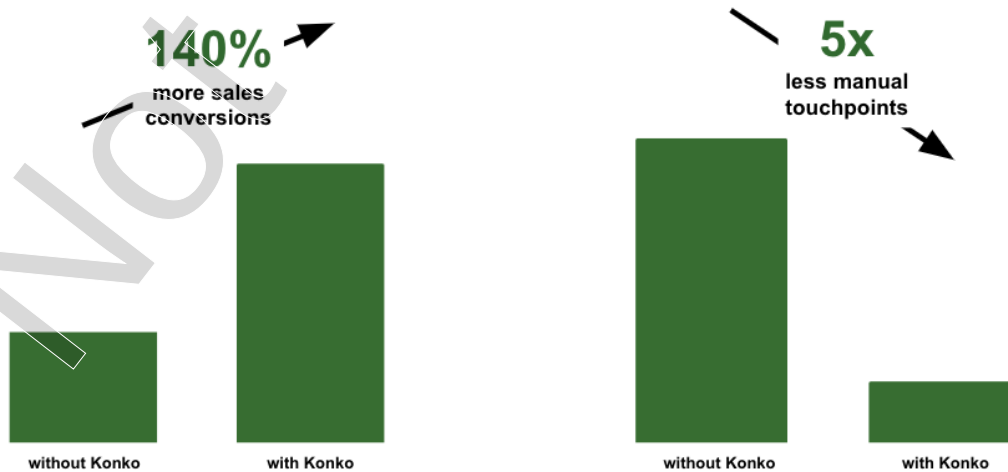
Exhibit 5 How Konko's AI Agent Architecture Worked

Source: Company documents.

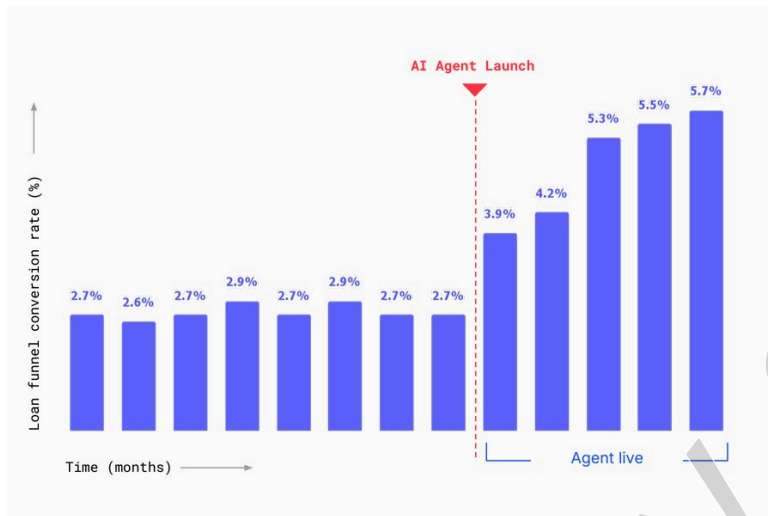
Exhibit 6a Sales Conversion Rate

Sales conversion rate
with and without our AI Agents

of human touch points to close a sale
with and without our AI agents



Source: Company documents.

Exhibit 6b Improvement in Overall Yield at fintech company

Source: Company documents.

Exhibit 7 Comparison between two opportunities

	FinTech Lenders	LatAm Clinics
# of individual prospects per country	20-30	1,000+
Difficulty of finding prospects	High	Low
Urgent Pain points	Heterogeneous Could be: - Growing revenue - Improving underwriting - Raising \$ to expand loan book	Homogenous Appear to be: - Growing revenue - Improving efficiency - Freeing physician time <i>further validation required</i>
Do they have humans doing what Kora does?	Sometimes	Yes, always
Alternatives ICPs have to improve conversions	Varied: - Improve UX - Pre-populating user data - Pulling user data from 3p DBs - Hiring people - Improving underwriting algos	Limited: - Hiring more / better staff - Training staff <i>further validation required</i>
End-user decision-making factors	Price	Price Service quality <i>further validation required</i>
Communication channels	Web portals, apps Sometimes: - SMS - e-mail - WhatsApp	WhatsApp (chat and voice) Sometimes: - Instagram - Facebook - Hubspot

Integration requirements:	In most cases: CRM Additional needs may exist: - Loan Origination System - Loan Management System - Underwriting Systems	Scheduling system Additional needs may exist: - CRM - EHR (electronic health record systems) <i>further validation required</i>
Degree of scrutiny for results tracking	High	TBD
Sales cycle for Kora	3-4 months	TBD
Customer Acquisition Channels	Lead marketplaces Web traffic	Referrals Web traffic

Source: Company documents.